

Direct To Net

Paramount Pictures is experimenting with a radically new distribution model by releasing a full-length movie exclusively over the Internet, skipping movie halls. For a week starting 19 December, Jackass 2.5 was available for free viewing on the Web (www.jackassmovie.com).



SpeedWire

FireWire has gotten a makeover. The data transfer interface will see transfer rates ramped up from 800 Mbps to 3.2 Gbps. FireWire is the commercial name for IEEE 1394, and the new standard will be called S3200. This is faster than the eSATA standard, used for connecting hard drives, and also USB 2.0.



Enter



S. Somasegar

Corporate Vice President
Developer Division Microsoft

S. Somasegar, Corporate Vice President, Developer Division at Microsoft, was in Hyderabad at the Microsoft India Development Centre early December; we caught up with him for some geek speak about the new Visual Studio (2008), among other things

How have programming enthusiasts reacted to the Visual Studio Express Editions? What does the new Visual Studio hold for them?

The Visual Studio 2005 Express Editions were huge successes for us—we saw over 17 million downloads for them, and we expect a similar response for Visual Studio 2008. We realised that not everyone had access to a high-speed Internet connection—especially in developing countries—so we've even decreased the download size of each Express Edition to about 30-40 MB.

How newbie-friendly is VS 2008?

We've designed the software with one thing in mind: people with a basic understanding of programming should be able to start developing their software fifteen minutes after they start Visual Studio for the first time.

What do the Express Editions offer teams of enthusiasts in terms of collaboration?

Right now, nothing—the collaboration features are present in Visual Studio Team System right now, but that doesn't mean we won't see these features trickling down to the Express Editions in future releases. Distributed development is growing today, and it's going to be a core scenario to think about when we develop future editions. Teams should be able to share application spaces no matter where they are. The Express Editions do have better collaboration features than the previous versions, but still not as much as we'd like.

CRIMINOMICS

Crime Pays, And How!

A few weeks ago, the FBI launched Operation Bot Roast II, and busted a ring of cyber-criminals, who were then charged with running a botnet (a network of compromised computers under the control of a central server) that spanned a million computers worldwide—and caused losses worth \$20 million (Rs 80 crore). So how exactly do phishers, rootkit makers, and “botmasters” manage to make their money? The system is complicated and ingenious, and like any efficient criminal enterprise, it operates behind multiple, difficult-to-penetrate layers.

For sale in this underground “cybereconomy” are products that automate the creation of Trojans. Even support services are provided for a period of time, usually one year. Most of these Trojan-spewing rings work out of Germany and Eastern European countries, but their services are available globally. Botnets can be “rented” out for spamming or launching DoS attacks. In 2007's worst security attack is believed to have affected millions of computers—which came to be called the Storm botnet. Botnets, as mentioned, depend on a central command-and-control server. Locating it and shutting it down is extremely difficult



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

because of evasive measures—like DNS masking—that the botmasters adopt.

Another hotbed of piracy, China is home to a virtual industry that rakes in millions of dollars for its players. A study by researchers at Peking University in Beijing and the University of Mannheim in Germany has shed some insights into how this economy works. Malicious code has high value, with the market price for packages of Trojan generator and evasion services ranging from tens to thousands of Chinese Yuan Renminbi (RMB). (1 RMB is about Rs 5.) Selling user data to third parties means big money as well. The modus operandi is to

attract visitors to sites by offering freebies like music and videos. The users' IPs are logged and sold to cyber-crooks. Upon the next visit, the visitors are redirected to malicious sites that install malware on the victims' machines. 10,000 IPs are sold for 40 to 60 RMB.

Gamers make up one of the most frequently-targeted groups. Password theft and loss of in-game credits is rampant: in fact, a batch of Seagate's hard disks sold in Taiwan was reported to have come installed with Trojans that stole MMORPG passwords and other account information.

The kind of criminals we're talking about use bulletin boards to communicate with each other and advertise services.

The good guys in this fight are the security and anti-virus firms, who have been slowly buckling under the onslaught of the attacks. For now, online crime seems to pay, and lot.

SOCIALLY OPEN

Facebook Opens Up

The social networking world has been seeing some not-insignificant upheavals of late. A little while ago, it was Google's attempt to break down the walled gardens of social



Security Watch

Patch IE, Update Flash Player

The Problem

Vulnerabilities have been reported in Adobe Flash Player as well as in Internet Explorer (6 and 7). The former is “Highly Critical” according to security firm Secunia, and the latter is worse—“Extremely Critical.”

The IE vulnerabilities are four in number, and one of them is reportedly being actively exploited. Successful exploitation can mean your computer being used to execute arbitrary code (read: it can be taken over).

The Flash Player vulnerabilities are in versions prior to 9.0.115.0, and there happen to be as many as 10 of them. There are also multiple things that an attacker can now do as a result of the vulnerabilities, but being safe is only a matter of updating the software.

The Solution

If you have Flash Player 9.0.48.0 and earlier, you need to update to version 9.0.115.0; get it from www.stage.adobe.com/go/getflash. As regards the IE vulnerability, if you have XP SP2 with IE6, visit <http://tinyurl.com/2r63sb>. For XP SP2 with IE7, visit <http://tinyurl.com/2qdbqv>

networking sites by launching OpenSocial, a set of APIs for creating applications compatible across various such sites. And now, Facebook has jumped into the fray by allowing competitors to use its source code and create interoperable applications. For once, Google has been caught off guard.

Senior executives at Facebook have announced that the architecture for its development platform would be licensed to its competitors. This would mean that applications developed for Facebook could run on sites like Bebo, Hi5, or Orkut. So theoretically, it would be possible to “tattoo” your Bebo friends or to send a “hatching egg” to Friendster buddies, which is now only possible within Facebook. Bebo, a social network popular in the UK, has already redesigned its platform so that it can host features found only on Facebook. Last we checked, they had iLike—one of the most-used Facebook applications—on their front page, no less.

For Google with its OpenSocial, Facebook's move will be hard to counter. Facebook has

cornered a large slice of the social networking pie, and has thousands of third-party developers around the world playing around with their API to make great, good, and downright silly applications (like throwing a cow at friends). These apps have large user bases, and developer support for them is strong. With an entirely new format and platform, this loyalty will be hard for Google to break, which it has to if it is to have any hope of catching the social networking bus.

OpenSocial is, for now, just a concept with lots of potential (those millions of Gmail accounts and Orkut users)—nothing concrete. It makes sense for other social networking sites to piggyback on Facebook and use its development platform. There is the danger that those sites could look start looking like clones of Facebook and lose their identity, but that's a chance they seem to be willing to take.

In related news, other sites—like LinkedIn and Friendster—have opened up their sites for developers. Both LinkedIn and Friendster are partners in Google's OpenSocial

HOT

Exercise And The Wii

The world's getting in on the get-off-ya-arse gaming wave—what could be better than losing weight while gaming? There's even Wii Fit to keep you, well, fit! Sure, you look like a total chump while you're at it, but people have done worse to get in shape.

It Doesn't Help!

According to a study by the British Medical Journal, gaming on the Wii doesn't expend enough energy to count as “real exercise”, so stop fooling yourself, and instead of getting off yer arse and gaming, get off yer arse and go for a jog!

initiative, though there is speculation that they would also enable their platform to allow interoperability with Facebook.

For users the world over, all this would mean the breaking down of the walls around the individual sites, enabling them to seamlessly connect with friends and contacts across networks. But naturally, this means a trade-off between convenience and identity...

Do you use your cellphone to access the Web using GPRS/EDGE/WAP?

(You, too, can participate in this poll—at www.thinkdigit.com)

☐ A Yes, I surf the Web on mobile daily

☐ B Yes I use it only once-twice a week

☐ C I don't, because I feel it is not secure (Bad experiences, if any)

☐ D No; speeds are very slow. (Name the service provider)

Option B. I use it only twice a week, and that too for checking e-mails and offline PMs. The pathetic speeds are waste of time and on top of that we have to pay huge bills every month. Its my last resort on the Internet but its useful when I'm on vacation.

Gaurish Sharma
Jaipur



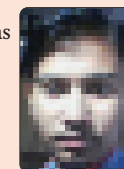
I'll definitely go with option D. I don't use the Mobile phone for surfing simply because the speeds are extremely slow and expensive too with my service provider—Vodafone.

Sukhdeep Singh Kohli
Jalandhar



I have a Symbian phone and using GPRS is such a breeze that I can get info of anything on the go—anywhere, anytime. In addition, I use it as modem with my PC too.

Rajesh Kumar Jaiswal
Jaipur



Option D. I did use GPRS when I had nokia N-Gage QD for the N-Gage Arena service to talk to other N-Gage users and download games. After I sold the N-Gage, I got GPRS deactivated—there was no point paying so much for slow speeds.

Niranjan Naik
Pune



I'll go for option D. I don't surf the Web on my mobile since I heard that speeds aren't too good. I don't mind trying to surf on my mobile phone, though.

Prakash Jose Kakkatt
Muvattupuzha, Kerala



My choice is option D. I never even think of connecting my Mobile phone for surfing as the speed is as slow as a snail. In place of that, I'd love using my Laptop for surfing by connecting through AirTel Broadband.

Amit Anand
Jharkhand



(You, too, can participate in this poll—at www.thinkdigit.com)

Opinion Poll